

of internal upheaval for the DC. Yet, the long-term solution not merely to basic socio-economic reforms but also to the problem of Italian Communism and the captivity of Italian Socialism would seem to lie in this direction. In other words, Christian Democracy, in the interest of preserving democratic institutions, must encourage exactly the reunification of Italian Socialism and other Left-Wing democratic forces in Italian society which will, in the long run, remove the very conditions which have been responsible for the political dominance of the DC over the last ten years. It is still a moot question whether the statesmanship of Signor Fanfani and his collaborators is equal to this singular task.

Predicaments of the Voting Intellectual

by

P. M. PASINETTI

In the political life of Italian intellectuals the most outstanding event of the last year or two has been the abandonment of the Communist Party, during the Hungarian crisis, by a number of writers and artists who had significantly belonged to it. Or if not the most outstanding, certainly the event has been the best advertised. Indeed, it is well known that intellectuals of some caliber can count on an exceptional, and often absurdly large, degree of publicity at all stages of a dramatic communist career: at the entrance, during the performance, and at the exit. Although intense and serious personal crises may have accompanied such developments for many of the dissenting writers and artists, their general "case" does not seem to contain much startling novelty in comparison with other similar crises, for instance in this country, in earlier days.

The position of the artist and writer, in his connection with politics, seems fated always to present certain peculiarities; it is even too obvious that the very outlook on life, the

"reading of the world" which the writer and the artist propose for themselves, will inevitably be guided by an awareness of complexities and contradictions that will make them appear, to say the least, unreliable to the "pure" politician. A "good riddance" attitude toward those defections, on the part of communist chiefs, might then even acquire a semblance of justification. In other words, while one does not wish to underestimate the significance of recent exits from the Communist Party, their importance should not be exaggerated either: they were partly foregone conclusions, and they have not, as it seems statistically, any great political weight. The grass roots of the party, or, in Italian parlance, the basis, *la base*, seems to possess no instruments to register the inner crisis of this or that painter or novelist, however important it may have been psychologically and symbolically. That is one first illustration of our present general theme: the sense of inanity of the intellectual who wishes to be satisfactorily influential in politics. Such events as the final fiasco of the one "intellectual" communist weekly, *Il contemporaneo*, have a similar limited importance. It was said, incidentally, that the paper folded because "capitalists" failed to place their advertisements in it. Why, a Northern industrialist is reported to have asked, should I support people whose aim is my ruin? His view was considered "brutal."

Of course, as there have been the dissidents, so there have been those who, on the contrary, have reaffirmed their orthodox and disciplined stand. "Younger" Communists like Mario Alicata and Pietro Ingrao, both of them people with literary and journalistic backgrounds (Alicata started in the years around 1940 as a literary critic) have strengthened their positions at key cultural posts in the party. Among members who have retained their party affiliation, the most symptomatic at this point seem to me those who may be loosely called the opportunists. The term needs qualification. I mean by it the people who see the opportunity to get concrete results through their allegiance to a large and well organized party. Even a year ago in Rome, among young members of the cultural fringe of that party (people belonging to the film world, for instance), one could hear in conversation

statements to the effect that that was hardly the moment to leave the organization; on the contrary, some of these people maintained that its inner confusion after de-Stalinization, Hungary, Khrushchev, etc., would mean greater inner mobility and with it the chance for the card-carrying intellectual to get results from his thinking and debating. Such a hope, in the light also of later events, appears preposterous, especially in one sense: namely, that the hoped-for debate seems to have consisted mainly of electoral power-strategy, devoid of any significant ideological content. The leader of the party, Togliatti, as everyone knows, has been put on the inactive list during the campaign for reasons of health; he also more generally appears to be on his way out. The most sensitive observers have reported, in the last few weeks preceding the May 25 elections, that the debate on succession to the leadership hardly resembles at all the great ideological debates which have usually accompanied such transfers of power and given them meaning. "In the present night," says one commentator, "all communist cats have become grey." Which means, to conclude, that the party seems hardly to offer the "opportunist," in exchange for loyalty, that meaningful relationship between thought and deed which is the aim of the *engagé* intellectual.

Oddly enough, on the opposite side, among the Christian Democrats, a brand of "opportunism" in the same special sense seems also characteristic. The young Christian Democratic intellectual is perhaps less likely to be a frustrated individual than his Communist counterpart because of the very breadth of his party and the overtness with which its inner varieties are admitted and discussed. Again, I have mainly empirical views; in talking to culturally representative members of that party I have sometimes had a vague impression of "anything goes," of an open-mindedness too good to be true, too broad to be good; or, at least, there was the suggestion that any issue one may bring up had already been foreseen, and that that large, varied party was the best instrument to attempt its solution. There is no telling how effectively such an attitude may work on the politically ambitious young. There is room for you. Come with us if you want to participate in getting things done. Nor is the magic,

intangible lure of political power ever to be discarded. I recall the thrilled sense of emulation with which some young people would watch the present Minister of Finance, Andreotti, the most successful among the highest-ranking Christian Democrats of the younger generation. If a young man possesses the necessary intelligence, industry, strategic sense, physical energy, he longs to see them applied. Will some politically eager Italians be thinking that the chance of active engagement is well worth a Mass? And if not, taking the gloomy view, will the alternative be a clearer conscience but no political hopes?

The alternative may also be a position of utter uncertainty. Although it would be a grave mistake to conceive of the Italian situation in terms of Christian Democrats vs. Communists, and the vital importance of smaller parties is universally recognized, the fact is that once the average Italian intellectual has discarded the two largest parties, as many do, almost as a matter of course too obvious to be even mentioned, he may be very uncertain as to where to turn. The failure of socialist unification has deprived him of what he envisaged as a relatively large "Labour" solution to his problem of not wasting his vote. There are, of course, intellectuals who vote Nenni-Socialist; in the cases I have known most closely, they did so more or less in order to let Nenni know that he has an independent backing and to urge him to break his communist ties. There is something oblique, basically a little hopeless about that way of voting.

Leaving aside such parties as extreme rightists, monarchists, neo-fascists, as hardly worth mentioning in a note on the Italian intelligentsia in the face of the elections, there remains the one recent, and, in the optimists' view, most glowing hope: the Radical-Republican alliance. Its place in the present line-up of Italian party politics is indicated by the other writers on this symposium. We may briefly amplify here by saying that if there is one ticket backed by a recognizable and significant part of Italian intellectuals, this is it. To give the idea in practical terms for our present purposes: it is a safe guess that a majority of the Italian writers known in the English-speaking world in the last years will vote for that coalition. There is more than that; there is a

sense of direct participation. Elio Vittorini is one of its candidates, on the "electoral list" in Milan; so is Guido Calogero, the philosopher and former member of the Constituent Assembly: he too is known to our readers. Another illuminating example is that of Elena Craveri Croce, one of the brilliant and intellectually active daughters of the philosopher, Benedetto Croce, who, besides being one of the primary intellectual forces of modern Italy, was a leader in the Liberal Party. It was from the Liberal Party that the present Radicals originated, through a split, several years ago; they are now not implausibly allied to the old "historical republicans." Theirs is the old lay and reforming spirit which has always represented an important segment of Italian thought. Significantly also, among the candidates we saw the names of the lawyers Leopoldo Piccardi and Achille Battaglia, who were connected with the recent widely advertised trial of the Bishop of Prato, significant as a test of Church-State relationships. Of the two weeklies which support the coalition, the more authoritative is *Il mondo*, whose editor, Mario Pannunzio, is also a candidate; one of its regular contributors is Ennio Flaiano, whose novel is known in this country. Alberto Moravia is a regular contributor to the other of the two weeklies, *L'espresso*, which was lately mentioned in this country for the campaign it conducted against the Minister of Finance accused of fiscal favoritism toward persons highly connected with the Vatican. *L'espresso* fancifully indicates the possible future danger of Italy as the arising of an "incense curtain." It is hard to predict what success the coalition may have in terms of measurable political weight; but we are not alone in granting it possibly the largest measure of attention in the coming election. It is evidently providing many men of culture with an occasion to give a vote without the feeling that the vote is either "oblique" or just simply wasted.

If all fails, the final demonstration could be that of the incompatibility between fully serious intellectual life on the one side, and political activity on the other. This is a universal problem, but it may be that in Italy it appears more urgently and nakedly than elsewhere.

Parties and Policies

by

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On the twenty-fifth of May the two branches of the Italian Parliament, Chamber of Deputies and Senate, will undergo a complete renewal.

This event needs to be pointed out not so much because of the inevitable sensationalism that accompanies any election, but because of the importance of the electoral results in relation to the consolidation of Italian democracy.

The democratic regime in Italy has not yet entered, so to speak, the "safety zone." The communists and their allies still represent a real danger for democratic institutions. The same can be said for the opposing forces of the fascist right. Therefore, a weakening of truly democratic strength could have serious consequences.

Moreover, there is another important aspect of the Italian elections which must not be underestimated, namely, that in thirteen years since the liberation this is the first time that concrete and precise problems are being placed before the electorate. The phase of dramatic alternatives between democracy and communism, though not completely superseded, still does not comprise all the themes of the present electoral campaign. The problems of institutional reform are brought to the fore, basic questions about economic orientation are raised, and proposals for a real participation of Italy in the European Market are advanced. In short, there is an awareness that after years of fruitful reconstruction, after positive achievement in the social field, after the difficult task of guaranteeing freedom and democracy, the time has arrived to add up the results: not to deny what has been done, but to draw from what has been accomplished the energy and stimulus for new forward steps.

For these reasons, all political groups consider the